

by crocodiles are quite common.

Before going for fishing, 15-year-old Mama Behera stops midway and looks at the memorial of her father Madhusudan Behera in Dangamal village. "My father was the in-charge of some caged crocodiles. One day, one of them attacked and killed him," she says. In recognition of Madhusudan's dedication, the forest department built a memorial for him. "My father treated crocodiles as friends but they don't trust anyone as friends. They crush and chew the hands that feed them," says Mama and then picks up the small net and moves to the river side. "Life is like that here." The irony is that Mama is endangering her life only to catch fish to feed two captive crocodiles—33-year-old and 2.50-metre-long Gori and 32-year-old and 2.85-metre-long Hyderabad—both white females. It's a compulsion for her because she has to support her mother and brother.

Her neighbour Jeeta, 40, shows a deep bite mark on her right knee. One day while she was catching fish, a crocodile crept up from nowhere and caught her. Alert villagers saved her in time, however. Sarthi Behera, 40, who lost her arm to crocodiles, has a similar story. She saved herself by going for the crocodile's eyes.

Nature and Wildlife Conservation Society of India records show that crocodiles killed 15 human beings between 1981 and 2000. But forest officials say that these claims are often exaggerated. "Between 2004 and early 2008 only three persons, who had intruded into protected habitats, were killed and 11 others were injured. Besides, 15 cows or other domestic animals were dragged away by crocodiles," they say.

During the floods of 2008, crocodiles created panic among people as they crawled into villages. A dedicated and experienced squad of labourers was deployed to drive away the crocodiles. Using indigenous techniques, these 'experts' chased back six crocodiles. Six more reptiles were trapped by this squad and later released in the wild.



"Whenever we receive information of crocodiles entering a village we rush the squad. Otherwise, patrolling the park is a risky job as estuarine crocodiles are very aggressive," says Behera, adding, "they are more dangerous than tigers and are silent killers. The only sound they make is hissing like pythons when their territory is trespassed."

Besides facing fatal attacks by the crocodiles, the villagers allege that they have to cope with the harassment by forest officials. "Nobody saves us from crocodiles but when we attack them in self-defence we are harassed by forest officials," says Arun Sethi, a villager. When Surekha, 17, was attacked by crocodiles, the forest officials threatened her father Purna Chandra that the family would face serious consequences if they reported the incident. The reason: their village falls in the restricted

area. This was not all. Nakul, a neighbour, who had saved her, was also threatened and asked why he had intruded the restricted area. In fact, Nakul himself was later attacked by crocodiles. "I had to spend Rs 14,000 on treatment, but there was no help from the government," says Nakul.

The attacks aren't just limited to the restricted areas. People in Dangamal have still not forgotten how Sattar Mian, who did not even trespass, was mauled and killed by a wild crocodile. Sattar was moving in the area close to the river when a crocodile dragged him away and killed him.

Ganesh Mandal of village Singrapal under Gupti block also lost his wife Maran Mandal to a crocodile when she took goats to the bank of the Pathsala river that leads to the core area. A huge crocodile leapt from the water and dragged her away. "After a search I found my wife's body with her